Complete Setup Manual: Ableton Live 10 + USB MIDI on Omarchy

End-to-End Guide: WINE Installation, Prefix Setup, Ableton Live 10, ALSA MIDI Bridge & MP3 Codecs

> **System Overview**
> - **Operating System:** Omarchy (Arch Linux-based, PipeWire audio backend)
> - **Compatibility Layer:** WINE (64-bit `WINEPREFIX`, `wow64` mode) & Winetricks
> - **DAW Software:** Ableton Live 10 (64-bit)
> - **Supported Hardware:** Any Class-Compliant Plug-and-Play USB MIDI Controller (e.g., Korg nanoKONTROL, keyboards, pad controllers)

1. Install WINE, Winetricks & Linux Audio/Codec Dependencies

Before installing Ableton, install WINE, Winetricks, 32-bit/64-bit ALSA MIDI libraries, and 64-bit GStreamer codecs (required by `winegstreamer` for MP3 decoding and multimedia initialization).

1. **Enable the `multilib` repository (if not already active):**
   Required on Arch/Omarchy for 32-bit compatibility libraries. Edit `/etc/pacman.conf` and ensure `[multilib]` and its `Include` line are uncommented, then sync with `sudo pacman -Syu`.
2. **Install WINE, Winetricks, and base dependencies:**
   ```
   sudo pacman -S wine winetricks wine-mono wine-gecko cabextract
   ```
3. **Install ALSA audio and MIDI bridge libraries:**
   ```
   sudo pacman -S alsa-utils alsa-lib alsa-plugins lib32-alsa-lib lib32-alsa-plugins pipewire-alsa
   ```
4. **Install 64-bit GStreamer multimedia plugins (for MP3 decoding):**
   ```
   sudo pacman -S gst-plugins-base gst-plugins-good gst-plugins-bad gst-plugins-ugly gst-libav
   ```
5. **Grant hardware audio and MIDI permissions to your user:**
   ```
   sudo usermod -aG audio $USER
   ```
   Log out and back in if your user was not previously in the `audio` group.

2. Initialize & Configure the WINE Prefix

Create a clean 64-bit WINE environment, install essential Windows fonts/runtimes, and explicitly enable the ALSA driver in the WINE registry so ALSA MIDI ports appear in Ableton.

1. **Initialize a 64-bit WINE prefix:**
   ```
   WINEARCH=win64 WINEPREFIX=~/.wine wineboot -u
   ```
   *If prompts appear to install Mono or Gecko, click **Install**. (To use a custom folder instead of `~/.wine`, replace the path and pass that same `WINEPREFIX` to all subsequent commands).*
2. **Install core fonts and Windows components via Winetricks:**
   ```
   winetricks corefonts vcrun2015 l3codecx
   ```
   `corefonts` prevents missing UI text in Ableton menus, `vcrun2015` supplies Visual C++ runtimes, and `l3codecx` registers Windows MP3 codec support alongside GStreamer.

3. **Enable ALSA MIDI alongside PulseAudio/PipeWire in the WINE Registry:**
   - Launch the Registry Editor: `wine regedit`
   - Navigate to: `HKEY_CURRENT_USER\Software\Wine\Drivers`
   - Edit or create the String Value named `Audio` and set its value to:

     ```
     pulse,alsa
     ```

4. **Restart the WINE background server** to apply all configuration changes:

   ```
   wineserver -k
   ```

3. Install Ableton Live 10

1. **Extract your Ableton Live 10 (64-bit) Windows installer** archive in Linux so `Setup.msi` or `Ableton Live 10 Installer.exe` is accessible on your drive.
2. **Run the installer inside WINE:**

   ```
   wine ~/Downloads/Ableton\ Live\ 10\ Suite\ Installer.exe
   ```

   If your download contains an `.msi` file instead of an `.exe`, run it with `wine msiexec /i Setup.msi`. Follow the standard Windows setup wizard using the default `C:\ProgramData\Ableton\...` path.
3. **Launch & Authorize Ableton Live 10:**
   - Start Ableton from your application launcher or terminal:

     ```
     wine "C:\ProgramData\Ableton\Live 10 Suite\Program\Ableton Live 10 Suite.exe"
     ```

   - Authorize via the browser or offline authorization file (`Authorize.auz`), and turn **Automatic Updates** to **Never** under **Options > Preferences > Licenses Maintenance** to prevent Windows updater conflicts.

4. Connect & Verify Any USB MIDI Controller in Linux

WINE enumerates ALSA MIDI hardware during startup. Always connect your controller before launching Ableton.

1. **Plug in your USB MIDI controller(s)** *before* starting Ableton Live 10.
2. **Verify Linux and WINE MIDI client detection:**

   ```
   aconnect -l
   ```

   Confirm both your controller (e.g., `client 24: 'nanoKONTROL'` or any USB MIDI device) and `client 128: 'WINE midi driver'` appear on the list (client numbers vary dynamically).
3. **Optional manual port routing:** If WINE does not link to a controller automatically, connect the ports using the client IDs shown by `aconnect -l` :

   ```
   aconnect <controller_client>:0 <wine_client>:0
   aconnect <wine_client>:1 <controller_client>:0
   ```

5. Configure MIDI & Mapping in Ableton Live 10

Open **Options > Preferences** (`Ctrl + ,`) and select the **Link/MIDI** tab to configure your controller:

1. **Control Surface (Optional):** If your device has an official Ableton script (such as Akai APC, Novation Launchpad, or Ableton Push), select it from the **Control Surface** dropdown and match its **Input** and **Output** ports. Otherwise, leave it set to **None**.

2. **Configure MIDI Ports (Bottom Section):** Enable the appropriate switches for your controller's Input port:

Port Toggle	When to Enable (On / Yellow)
Track	Enable for **keyboards, drum pads, and sequencers** so they can play notes into MIDI instrument tracks.
Remote	Enable for **knobs, faders, and buttons** (like the Korg nanoKONTROL) to use MIDI Learn mode (`Ctrl + M`).
Sync	Enable only for **external hardware synths or drum machines** that need Ableton's MIDI clock tempo signal.

3. **Manual MIDI Mapping:** Press `Ctrl + M` (or click **MIDI** in the top-right corner), click any control in Ableton, move the physical fader/knob/button on your controller, and press `Ctrl + M` again to exit.
4. **Save as Default Template:** Go to **Options > Preferences > File Folder** and click **Save Current Set as Default** so your controller setup loads automatically in every new project.

6. Performance Tips for MP3s & Audio

- **Speed up MP3 imports:** Ableton decodes MP3s via WINE's GStreamer bridge into a temporary WAV file on first load. Once decoded once, it stays in your **Decoding Cache** folder (configured under **Preferences > File Folder**) for instant future loading.
- **Batch-convert large files natively on Linux:** For long DJ mixes or large sample packs, convert MP3s to WAV directly in Linux before importing to bypass WINE translation overhead:

```
for f in *.mp3; do ffmpeg -i "$f" "${f%.mp3}.wav"; done
```

- **Disable Auto-Warp on long tracks:** In **Options > Preferences > Record Warp Launch**, set **Auto-Warp Long Samples** to **Off** to prevent CPU spikes when dragging in full-length audio files.